

History & Folklore Coriander has been used throughout Asia, northern Africa, and Europe for well over 2,000 years. It is listed in the Ebers papyrus (dating to about 1500 BCE), and apparently was much employed in ancient Egypt. The herb reached China during the Han Dynasty (202 BCE–220 CE). Pliny (23–79 CE) describes its use “for spreading sores ... diseased testes, burns, carbuncles, and sore ears, fluxes of the eyes, too, if woman’s milk be added.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Coriander is more often used as a spice than as a medicine. Nevertheless, an infusion of the herb is a gentle remedy for flatulence, bloating, and cramps. It settles spasms within the gut and counters the effects of nervous tension. Coriander is also chewed to sweeten the breath, especially after consumption of garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59). Coriander seed has been used as an expectorant to treat coughs and bronchitis, and in traditional Middle Eastern medicine it is taken to calm anxiety and aid sleep. The ground seed is applied externally as a rub for rheumatic pain. In Europe, it has traditionally been thought to possess aphrodisiac properties.

Caution Do not take coriander essential oil internally.

Cornus officinalis (Cornaceae) Shan Zhu Yu

Description Deciduous tree reaching 13 ft (4 m) with glossy elliptical leaves and bright red oval berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China, Japan, and Korea, this tree is cultivated in central and eastern China. The fruit is harvested when ripe in autumn.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents *Shan zhu yu* contains an iridoid glycoside (verbenalin), saponins, and tannins. Verbenalin produces a mild tonic effect on the involuntary nervous system, especially that governing the digestive system.

History & Folklore Listed in the 1st-century CE *Divine Husbandman’s Classic* (*Shen’nung Bencaojing*), *shan zhu yu* is one of the constituents of the “Pill of Eight Ingredients,” used to “warm up and invigorate the yang of the loins.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses As an herb that “stabilizes and binds,” *shan zhu yu* is used principally to reduce heavy menstrual bleeding and unusually active secretions, including copious sweating, excessive urine, spermatorrhea (involuntary discharge of semen), and premature ejaculation.

Related Species Several *Cornus* species are used medicinally around the world. In Europe, the fruit and bark of the cornelian cherry (*C. mas*)

and the bark of common dogwood (*C. sanguinea*) are used as astringents and to relieve fever. The American boxwood (*C. florida*) was used by Native Americans as a fever remedy.

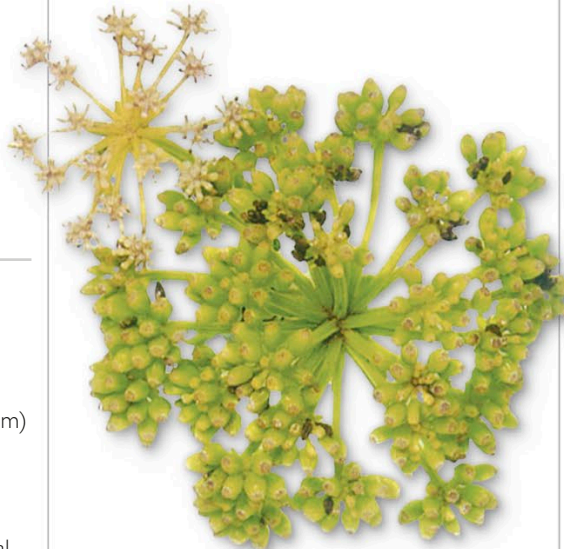
Crithmum maritimum (Apiaceae)

Sea Fennel, Samphire

Description Maritime herb growing to a height of 2 ft (60 cm). Has long, succulent, bright green leaves and clusters of small yellowish-green flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Sea fennel grows on the Atlantic, Mediterranean, and Black Sea coasts of Europe and Asia Minor. It is found on rocks and cliffs close to the sea, and gathered in early summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.



Sea fennel is rich in vitamin C and minerals.

Constituents Sea fennel contains a volatile oil, pectin, vitamins (especially vitamin C), and minerals.

History & Folklore A much-valued herb in the past, sea fennel fell into disfavor but is slowly becoming popular again as a vegetable, either pickled or eaten fresh. The English herbalist John Gerard described it in 1597 as “the pleasantest sauce, most familiar, and best agreeing with man’s body, both for the digestion of meats, breaking of stone, and voiding of gravel.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though it is currently little used in herbal medicine, sea fennel is a good diuretic, and it has potential as a treatment for obesity. Sea fennel has a high vitamin C and mineral content, and is thought to relieve flatulence and soothe the digestion. In this, the plant resembles its inland namesake, fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212). Glasswort (*Salicornia europaea*), also known as samphire, is an unrelated coastal plant with a high mineral content and is commonly eaten as a vegetable.

Croton spp. (Euphorbiaceae)

Dragon’s Blood, Sangre de Drago

Description Fast-growing tree reaching 49 ft (15 m) in height. It has large, heart-shaped leaves and greenish-white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Dragon’s blood is a rainforest tree native to northwestern Amazonia (from Bolivia to Colombia), preferring riverbanks and sites with disturbed soil. It is cultivated by the indigenous peoples there as an environmentally sustainable crop.

Parts Used Latex, sap, resin (fresh or dried), bark.

Constituents Key constituents within dragon’s blood include proanthocyanidins, mono- and diterpenes, an alkaloid (taspine), and a lignan (dimethylcedrusine). Many constituents, notably taspine and dimethylcedrusine, have potent anti-inflammatory and wound healing properties. Taspine also has cancer-fighting and antiviral activity.

History & Folklore Dragon’s blood derives its name from the deep red sap or latex that oozes from the tree when the bark is cut. A prized rainforest medicine, the latex is applied to wounds, fractures, skin infections, and insect bites. Internally,

it is taken to treat diarrhea and dysentery, stomach ulcers, viral infections, and as a vaginal bath before and following childbirth. The first written record of its use was in 1653 (Bernabe Cobo, *Historia del Nuevo Mundo*).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Dragon’s blood is a first-rate wound healer and has been described as a “liquid bandage.” Tissue healing and repair is strongly stimulated, while the chances of infection developing in open wounds and sores is minimized due to the marked antiseptic action of the latex and its ability to seal off the wound from the open air. The latex (fresh or dried) is a key remedy for herpes, including shingles and genital herpes, and fungal skin infections. Taken internally, it helps to treat and prevent gastrointestinal infection and peptic ulcers, and to control diarrhea in conditions such as ulcerative colitis. A patent U.S. medicine (Crofelemer) derived from dragon’s blood is licensed for the treatment of chronic diarrhea, typically in patients with HIV.

Related Species *C. lecheri* is most commonly used to make dragon’s blood, although similar *Croton* species grow in Central America. *C. flavens* (Yellow balsam), a traditional Mayan and Aztec remedy, is used for fever and infections, and as a wound salve. Dragon trees, such as the Socotra dragon tree (*Dracaena cinnabari*), are desert trees and unrelated to dragon’s blood, though some also produce a red latex.

Caution Can permanently stain clothing.